vote).[18] For many Western observers, the 2010 and 2012 elections were ample proof that Myanmar was changing for the better. A media-friendly politician appeared to be leading a movement towards democracy and the regime was opening up to foreign investment.

Politics in Myanmar, 2011–15

At a national level, the trends established in the period 2008–11 continued in 2011–15. The principal political dynamic has become the interaction between the military, their political wing (the USDP), the NLD and the growing influence of extremist Buddhist monks. To fully explain the current threat to the Rohingyas it is necessary to see how these three forces interact and, combined, make it hard for the Myanmar government to ease the repression (even if that were what it wanted to do).

The military and the USDP

The notional move to democracy has not changed the military's deep-seated tendency to see both domestic society and the international community as enemies.[19] As of now, the generals retain effective control over the economy (especially natural resources) and have spent the last seventy years at war with Myanmar's ethnic minorities. These two factors are deeply intertwined, as most of the mineral wealth lies in territory occupied by ethnic groups such as the Karen and the Shan. So far, the West has been too willing to deal with the military, believing either that it can be reformed, or that it is a force for stability[20] and that the military is right when it argues the NLD is not yet 'ready for government'.[21] Despite losing the 2015 elections, the reality is that the military is desperate to retain economic dominance, and their strategy 'is all about the land … the control of it and the prospering from its fruits'.[22] In addition, as discussed above, it has developed a mindset whereby only ethnically Burman Buddhists can hold power if the state is to endure.[23] In reality, if Myanmar has a future as a state, it has to acknowledge its ethnic diversity and it must be essentially federal in structure. In this respect, the army is a major obstacle to progress. It is content to see some degree of internal conflict (such as within Rakhine), as this fits its narrative that only it can preserve the state.[24]